AICloudStrategist

Discovery Call Script

Purpose: 30-minute first conversation with a prospect who has booked via /book.html, replied to a LinkedIn message, or been warm-introduced. The goal is to qualify, create trust, and end with one of three specific next steps — not to close on the call.

Tone: Consultative, specific, INR-first. Founder-led. Enterprise-reviewed.

Before the call: - Open their LinkedIn profile + company website in one tab - Have a blank notes doc ready with the template below - Join 3 minutes early, video on, professional background

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Minute 0–2 · Opening

> *"Hi [Name], Anushka here from AICloudStrategist. Thanks for carving out the 30 minutes. Can you hear me clearly?*
>
> *Before we start — two things. One, I run a tight agenda for these calls so we finish on time and you walk away with something concrete. Two, I'm going to ask you specific questions about your cloud footprint, spend, and architecture. Nothing I ask needs a confidential answer on this call — rough ranges are fine. If there's anything you'd rather not share, just say so and we'll move on.*
>
> *Sound fair?"*

Pause. Get a yes.

> *"Quick agenda: - 10 minutes on your environment — what you're running, where the pain is. - 10 minutes on how I work and whether there's a fit. - 10 minutes for your questions and next steps.*
>
> *Ready?"*

Minute 2–12 · Discovery (their 10 minutes)

Ask these in order. Listen for three times longer than you speak. Take notes verbatim.

Environment sizing (2 min)

1. "What clouds are you on today? AWS, Azure, GCP, or a mix?"
2. "Rough monthly spend across all of them — 2 lakh range, 10 lakh, 50 lakh?"
3. "What's the team structure? Is there a dedicated DevOps person, or is it shared responsibility?"

The trigger (4 min) — *the most important section*

4. "What made you click 'book a call' today? What happened recently that put cloud cost on your radar?"
5. "Has the CFO or CEO raised cloud cost specifically, or is this coming from engineering?"
6. "Walk me through the last bill surprise — what happened, what was the spike, what did you do?"
7. "If I asked your engineering lead 'what's our Reserved Instance coverage,' what would they say? And do you trust that answer?"

Current state (3 min)

8. "Who owns cloud cost inside the company today — is it formally assigned, or is it everyone's-and-no-one's problem?"
9. "Are you tagging resources? Is tagging coverage above or below 50% of spend?"
10. "Any previous consultant engagements or internal projects on cost? What happened — did it stick or did costs drift back?"

Urgency (1 min)

11. “If nothing changes, where is the bill 6 months from now?”
12. “And is that a problem you need to solve this quarter, next quarter, or this year?”

Minute 12–22 · How I work (my 10 minutes)

Tailor this block to what they said in discovery. Don’t deliver a canned pitch — pick the 3–4 bullets that match their pain and skip the rest.

The positioning (30 seconds — always)

> *“Quick context on how AICloudStrategist is structured so you know what you’re dealing with. I’m the founder — Anushka B. I’ve been in cloud, DevOps, and automation for 7 years. Every engagement I deliver is reviewed by a senior architect with 22+ years of Fortune 500 cloud-economics weight. That review layer is the piece small consultancies usually skip and big firms charge Fortune-500 rates for. Founder-led delivery, enterprise-reviewed output. That’s the pitch.”*

The entry service (for 5L+ monthly spend)

> *“The lead service for someone in your situation is the FinOps QuickStart. It’s a two-week engagement, fixed price between 75,000 and 1,50,000 depending on footprint complexity. At the end you get three things:*
>
> 1. *A ranked savings backlog with actual INR figures — not percentage hand-waving*
> 2. *A tagging and cost-allocation baseline your team owns forever*
> 3. *A 90-day implementation plan with named owners*
>
> *Typical client surfaces 15 to 30 percent addressable monthly spend in the first week alone. I’m not inventing that number — that’s the range I’ve hit on the engagements I’ve done.”*

The retainer hook (for teams ready for ongoing work)

> *“If the QuickStart surfaces enough that you want ongoing oversight, there’s a Managed FinOps Retainer — monthly cadence, weekly anomaly triage, monthly executive report, quarterly strategic deep-dive. Replaces the 40 to 80 lakh per year cost of hiring a full-time FinOps engineer. Only brought up if the QuickStart proves out; never forced.”*

The gain-share lever (for cost-sensitive prospects)

> *“One thing that separates us from most consultancies — for cost-reduction engagements, we offer a gain-share structure. There’s a savings floor, a percentage share of verified savings above the floor, a 12-month measurement window, and a cap. If savings don’t cross the floor, no gain-share is due — only the fixed fee. The Big-4 firms can’t do this because of how their billing structures work. We can, and it’s the thing clients tell me closes the deal.”*

What we don’t do (30 seconds — trust signal)

> *“One last thing on how I work. I don’t use proprietary tooling that disappears when the engagement ends. Everything we stand up — OpenCost, tagging taxonomies, Infracost pipelines, commitment portfolio trackers — is open source and stays with you. No vendor lock-in. No recurring licence fees. And I don’t subcontract delivery; if Anushka signs the SOW, Anushka does the work.”*

Minute 22–28 · Their questions

Let them drive. Answer specifically with INR figures and timeline commitments.

Prepared answers for the most common questions

“How is this different from AWS/Azure/GCP’s own cost-optimization advisors?”

> *“The native tools tell you what’s inefficient. They don’t have opinions about your architecture, your commitment strategy, or your tagging governance. They also don’t negotiate the trade-offs with engineering on your behalf. That’s the gap we fill — the judgment layer that sits between the*

> *dashboard and the decision."*

"What happens if the QuickStart doesn't find savings?"

> *"Every engagement I've done has surfaced at least 15% addressable spend. If somehow yours doesn't, the fixed fee is the only cost — no gain-share is due, and I'll tell you honestly that this isn't the engagement for you and refer you to a reliability or architecture focus instead. I'd rather lose the retainer than misrepresent the value."*

"Timeline — when could we start?"

> *"Two-week lead time for kickoff to accommodate IAM setup and data access. Delivery is two weeks from kickoff. So realistically, four weeks from today to ranked backlog in your inbox."*

"Who owns the data we share?"

> *"You do. Full stop. MSA has a standard data-protection clause — read-only access, no data leaves your environment without your written sign-off, all analysis artifacts delivered to you and deleted from our side 30 days post-engagement. Happy to share the clause in advance if that helps the legal conversation."*

"Can you share a reference?"

> *"I'll be honest — we're selective about reference calls because my earlier clients asked to stay anonymous. What I can share are detailed case studies on our proof page with the commercials redacted. Once we're past this discovery call and you're seriously evaluating, I'll put you in touch with a similar-sized prior client for a 15-minute reference conversation."*

Minute 28–30 · Close — three named next steps

Never end a discovery call with "let me know." Always offer three specific options, ordered by their apparent readiness.

> *"Let me leave you with three options for how this moves forward, and you pick what fits.*
>
> 1. ***You're convinced*** *— I send over a QuickStart proposal by end of day today, we sign this week, kickoff in two weeks.*
> 2. ***You want to see it work first*** *— I send over the Free Cloud Cost Health Check template we use, your team runs it, we meet next week to review findings. Zero cost, zero commitment.*
> 3. ***The timing isn't right this quarter*** *— I add you to a quarterly pulse email. One email every three months with one specific cloud-cost pattern I'm seeing across Indian mid-market. Unsubscribe any time. When the timing changes, you know where to find me.*
>
> *Which one fits?"*

Shut up. Let them pick.

Post-call (within 2 hours)

Within two hours, send a follow-up email with these elements — no later:

1. Subject line: `AICloudStrategist — recap + [next step they picked]`
2. Three-line summary of what they told you (proves you listened)
3. Explicit next step with a calendar invite or a document attached
4. One blog post link from aicloudstrategist.com/blog.html that matches their specific pain
5. Signature: Anushka B, Founder · aicloudstrategist.com · Rohini, Delhi

Never send the proposal as a CC — send a dedicated email with the proposal attached as a PDF, not a Google Doc link.

Red flags — when to walk away

- They want a detailed scope in writing before the discovery call (tire-kicker; politely decline)
- They ask for a fixed percentage of bill reduction guarantee before diagnosis (impossible commitment; won’t work)
- They’re simultaneously talking to 5+ consultants (race to the bottom on price; decline unless they accept a meaningful engagement fee)
- The “CFO is pressuring us” claim but they can’t describe a recent bill surprise (manufactured urgency)
- They want to pay on outcomes only, no fixed fee (no consultant can sustain this; end the conversation)

Green flags — push for close

- They volunteer a specific INR figure they’ve already tried to cut (they’ve already tried; they know the pain)
- They reference a specific service or region that surprised them (they’ve looked; they have data)
- They ask who reviews the work (they understand the senior-architect oversight matters)
- They ask about the gain-share floor and cap (they’re modeling the commercial envelope — this is buyer behavior)

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